Vedaranyam where he was being held. Then under the pretext of washing his hands, he went to the backyard accompanied by a lone guard.

And in the dark disappeared scaling the compound wall, leaving behind his khadi dhoti and white shirt. Next morning his body was found hanging from a tree in a nearby park. A blue lungi was found at the spot. The post-mortem was conducted the same day at Nagapattinam, 40 km from Vedaranyam.

The report, taking note of the saliva, emission of semen and stools, declared it a suicide. But the SIT story and post-mortem are riddled with loopholes that militate against forensic wisdom.[10]

The followers of Shanmugham had surrounded the SIT officials at the police station and demanded an explanation. Their action was justified.

The victims' supporters asserted that emission of saliva, stool and/or semen could also have come from his strangling. And if Shanmugham was tied up, how could he commit suicide? Neither were any skin cells found under his nails. Advocate Ramalinga Raju asked dramatically if it was humanly possible for Shanmugham to climb the tree first, then put the rope around his neck and then jump. All by himself. He refused to believe the victim would find a fourteen-foot-long rope in the middle of the night unless someone from the police station had abated his act. The advocate demanded a magisterial inquiry be set up immediately.

Again there were many questions asked while no answer was available. Why was Seetharaman allowed to visit Shanmugham, get his dinner from outside and chat with him for over an hour when a lawyer was not permitted to be present during the interrogation? It may be noted here that a lawyer is not allowed to sit during interrogation of an accused booked under TADA. None of the constables entrusted with Shanmugham's physical custody had any convincing answer to offer either. Stranger still was why the guards didn't carry any guns on their persons. They could have fired in the air to warn Shanmugham while he was fleeing. Even if an alarm was raised after his escape, the victim could not have reached the park, not more than fifty yards from the police station, and complete the act of suicide without anyone from the police station catching up with him.